

Goals, Planning, Tracking

IT Product Development

Innopolis University, 2026

Agenda

- Discussion questions
- Goals
- Threshold of success
- Strategic planning
- Tactical planning

Goals

Discussion questions

What is a goal?

What are properties of unambiguous goals?

How to communicate goals to other people?

SMART goals

A goal is an idea of the future or desired result that people envision, plan, and commit to achieve.“ - [Goal on Wiki](#)

The **SMART** goal format lets you state goals precisely so that others can agree on what success wrt. this goal is and later tell whether it was achieved.

SMART goal:

- **Specific**: what exactly will be done, and for whom?
- **Measurable**: what evidence or number proves it is done?
- **Achievable**: can we reach it with our skills, time, and resources?
- **Relevant**: does it align well with the project vision?
- **Time-bound**: by when, with a date?

SMART goal example

Example

By the Week 3 soft deadline, October 15, 2026, our team ships a minimum usable product in which a user completes the core task chosen in Week 2 end to end, and the customer accepts it at that week's meeting.

Properties

- **Specific** — the MUP vertical slice for the core task, built only from Must Have stories.
- **Measurable** — the core task runs end to end, and the customer's verdict is recorded as a DEC-nnn.
- **Achievable** — one course week, a 3–4 person team, using a candidate already reviewed in Week 2.
- **Relevant** — it is Submission 3 (7% of the grade) and the base for the Week 5 MVP.
- **Time-bound** — October 15, 2026, 23:59 (soft), October 16, 2026, 23:59 (hard).

Quiz

Why write SMART goals?

Threshold of success (ToS)

Discussion questions

What is success?

What is failure?

What is between them?

Threshold of success (ToS)

Threshold of success:

Minimum set of SMART goals that must **all** be achieved for the project to be considered a success by the stakeholders.

If one of the goals is not achieved, the project will be considered a failure.

Why need it:

- Helps focus on essential goals
- Increases chances for a clear project success
- Helps communicate goals to stakeholders
- Helps identify the most important risks that are necessary to manage

ToS steps

1. Gather the whole team
2. Build a minimum picture of failure (when should the project be considered a failure, informally?)
3. List failure statements (testable - “We didn’t do X”, “We didn’t meet Y”, etc.)
4. Convert failure statements to success statements
(testable - “We must do X”, “We must meet Y”)
5. Write a minimal set of SMART goals that cover the success statements

Guess the sequence of ToS steps

- Convert failure statements to success statements
- List failure statements
- Gather the whole team
- Write a minimal set of SMART goals that cover the success statements
- Build a minimum picture of failure

Discussion questions

What can be a failure statement for your team?

Planning

Discussion questions

What is planning?

Why do people plan?

When do people plan?

What types of planning do you know?

Planning types

Strategic

- Long-term
- Achieve global project goals
- Keep in mind the threshold of success

Tactical

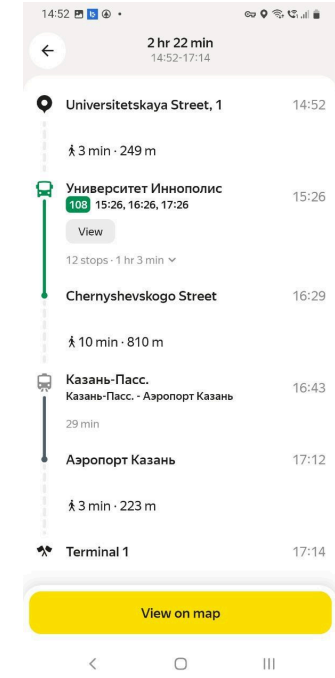
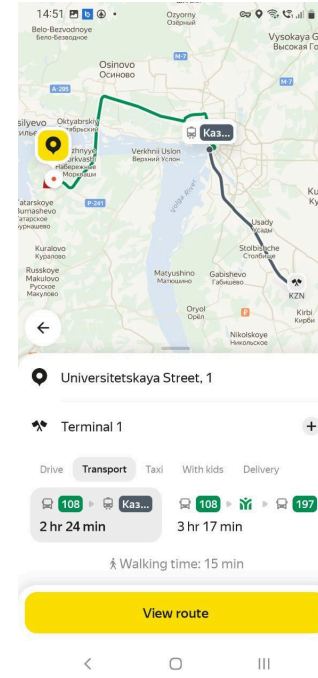
- Short-term
- Achieve local project goals
- Complete tasks
- Situational

Strategic planning

Strategic plan example

A navigation app provides a strategic plan

- a path from start to finish.



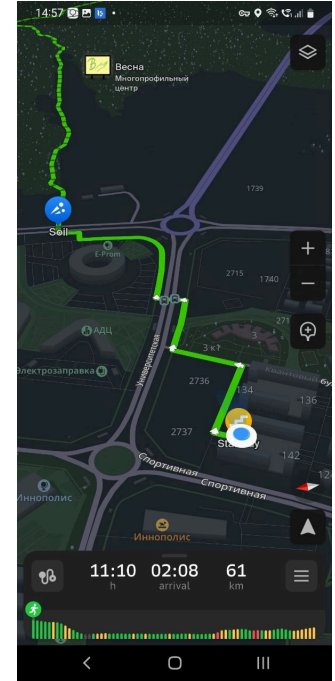
Strategic planning & tracking (level: global goals, sub-goals)

- **Define success wrt. your goals**
 - Make it testable (threshold of success)
 - Make sure all stakeholders agree (~80% of pain comes from skipping this step)
- **Develop a roadmap**
 - Decompose the path to success into steps (sub-goals, milestones)
 - Find a “zoom level” that works for your project
- **Monitor progress - “tracking”**
 - How much was done and how much remains?
 - Are we on track to complete promised deliverables?
 - Can stakeholders clearly see our progress?
- **Make contingency plans**
 - Define alternative solutions
 - Identify “point of no return” decisions
 - Identify risks

Tactical planning

Tactical planning example

The same navigation app provides a tactical plan
- a step-by-step path to a local goal (sub-goal)



Tactical planning (level: local sub-goals and tasks)

- **Define who is responsible**
 - Every task has a specific person responsible for completing it (“responsible”)
- **Define when the work is done**
 - There is Definition of Done for the work (task, user story, etc.)
- **Review completed work**
 - There is a separate person who verifies that a task was done (“accountable”)
 - Iteration demo
 - What went wrong?
 - What went right?
- **Adjust to fix discovered problems**
 - What should we keep from what went right?
 - Which steps should we take to improve iterations?

Similar to [The PDSA cycle](#)

Quiz

What is strategic planning?

What is tactical planning?

What will happen if we ignore strategic planning?

What will happen if we lack tactical planning?

Questions?